

LOCAL FARE
Dabbawalas with boxed lunches in their charge en route from Dadar to Andheri

- Dabbawalas hail from specific locations in the Maharashtra countryside, and belong to the Maratha community
- The white Gandhi cap is a must for dabbawalas
- Each group of dabbawalas accounts for expenses like hire charges for bicycles, loss of tiffin boxes and cycles and then divide earnings equally. A dabbawala earns between Rs 14,000 and 18,000 a month
- The *mukadam* or overseer resolves any disputes among the men under his command. Else, these issues are raised before the Mumbai Tiffin Box Suppliers Association and the Nutan Mumbai Tiffin Box Suppliers Charity Trust
- The trust controls four dharmashalas (charitable inns) at the pilgrimage centres of Bhimashankar, Jejuri, Alandi and Pandharpur
- According to a book by Shobha Bondre, underworld don Haji Mastan once offered to lend his name to the dabbawala association. The dabbawalas refused as they felt that he wanted to capitalise on their goodwill
- The dabbawalas were also featured in the movie *The Lunchbox* (2013) where friendship between the characters played by Irrfan Khan and Nimrat Kaur blossoms after a mix-up by one of the men in Gandhi caps—in reality, goof-ups by dabbawalas are a rarity
- Pre-2004, the number of dabbawalas was around 6,000
- The workforce includes two women
- Rates for picking up, delivering a lunchbox vary from Rs 500 to Rs 2,000 a month based on the location